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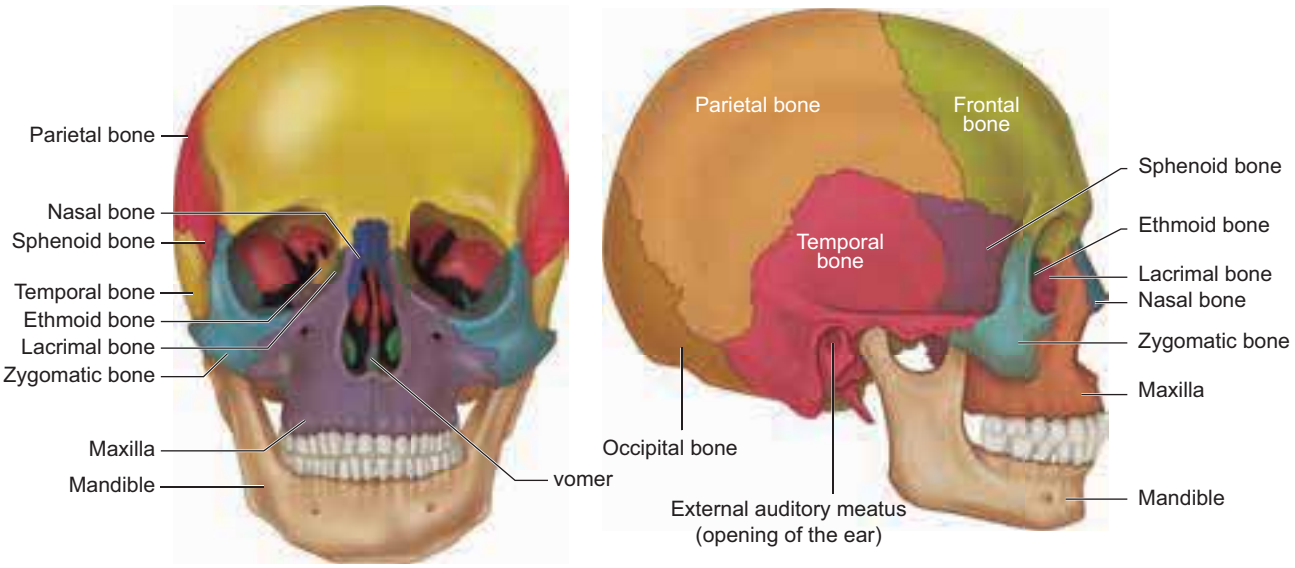


Figure 9. 7 Structure of the skull

prominent openings in the skull are **the orbits** and **the nasal cavity**. **Foramen magnum** is a large opening found at the posterior base of the skull**.** Through this opening the medulla oblongata of the brain descends down as the spinal cord.

b) The Vertebral Column

Vertebral column is also called the back bone. It consists of 33 serially arranged vertebrae which are interc onnected by cartilage known as intervertebral disc (Figure 9.8). The vertebral column extends from the base of the skull to the pelvis and forms the main frame work of the trunk. The vertebral column has five major regions. They are, **the Cervical**, **Thoracic**, **Lumbar**, **Sacrum** (5 sacral vertebrae found in the infant which are fused to form one bone in the adult) and **Coccyx** (4 coccygeal vertebrae found in the infant which are fused to form one bone in the adult).

Each vertebra has a central hollow portion, the neural canal, through which the spinal cord passes. The first vertebra is called as **the atlas** and the second vertebra

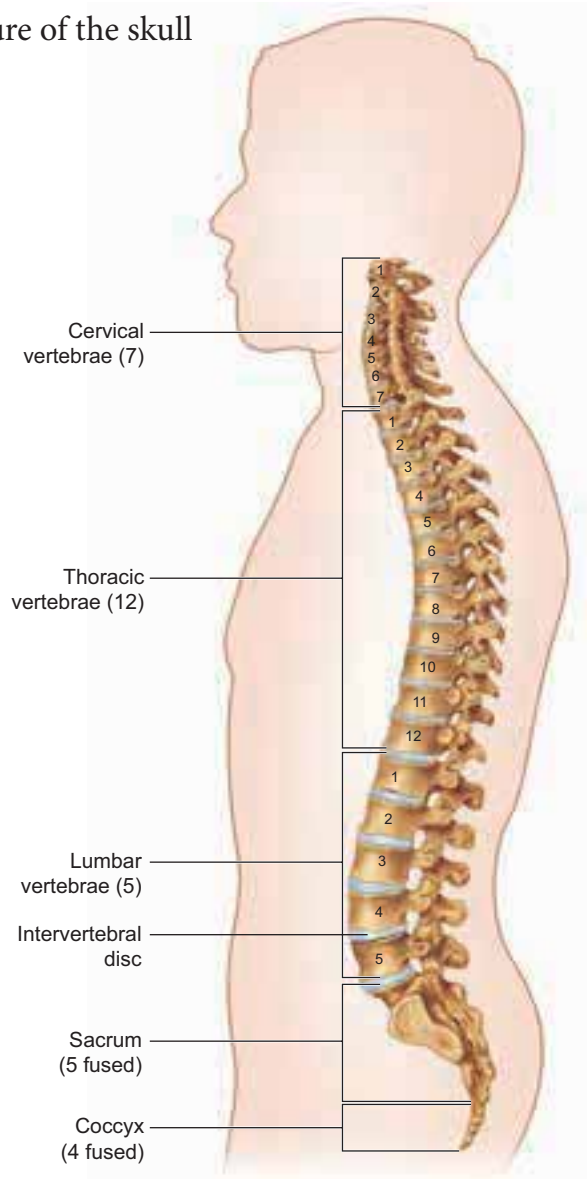


Figure 9. 8 Vertebral Column